kameez or a white turban, and were to wear black caps and a red *tilak* on their foreheads as an identification mark. Hindu women were directed to drape themselves fully in yellow cloth and wear an iron necklace in public. Hindus and Muslims were not allowed to live together anymore, and Hindus were ordered to display a yellow flag on their houses.[19] With a Hindu nationalist government in power in a conservative India, the decree touched a sensitive communal chord unleashing massive protests. Not only did the BJP condemn the decree, it took the matter up with the UN, the US, the EU, and other countries with common interests. Massoud Khalili, the United Front representative in India, condemned the decree. 'Hindu Afghans had been part and parcel of Afghanistan's culture. They have lived freely, worshipped freely, and wore whatever they liked and fought for Afghanistan's liberation each and every time', he stated.[20]

No common ground existed between India and the Taliban. The Taliban did not even figure heavily in parliamentary debates on terrorism, and whenever it did, it was mostly linked with Pakistan and the Kashmiri militants. For instance, in a heated joint parliamentary session on 28 August 2001, on the security scenario in the light of terrorist and other internal and external threats, the Taliban was the least discussed entity, with the popular notion being that India was doing little to secure its interests in Afghanistan.[21] The bigger concern vis-à-vis Afghanistan was that the prolonged conflict since the 1980s had prompted 12,083 Afghans to migrate to India by February 2001.[22] By November 2001, another 275 Afghan Sikh and Hindu families were stranded in Pakistan, hoping to travel to India by road.[23] Given the number of Afghan refugees in Pakistan, which ran into millions, and in different Western countries, which ran into hundreds of thousands, India was hosting a trifling number of Afghan migrants. Nonetheless, the issue was potent enough to raise a red flag.

Concerned about the plight of these migrants, India was also worried about the potential impact of growing Afghan refugees in India (however small their numbers may be in relative terms). Social hostility against Afghans, in the backdrop of the situation in Kashmir and the IC-814 hijacking incident, had gone up. Moreover, despite more than 65 per cent of these refugees being Hindu or Sikh, India refused to integrate or naturalise them.[24] Given the state of affairs in Afghanistan, it was impossible for them to return anytime soon. Not being a